UNIVERSITY OF MORATUWA

DEPARTMENT OF ELECTRONIC & TELECOMMUNICATION ENGINEERING



Assignment 03

EN3150 Pattern Recognition

Resource-Constrained CNN for Edge Image Classification

Group DINO

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GitHub: https://github.com/jaindusamaranayaka/EN3150-ConvNets-Image-Classifier

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1 Introduction

This report designs, trains and compares image classifiers for a resource-constrained edge device such as a microcontroller or a Raspberry Pi. Two custom convolutional neural networks (CNNs) were built from scratch: a standard CNN (**Model A**) and a lightweight CNN based on depthwise separable convolutions (**Model B**, under 100,000 parameters). They are compared with two ImageNet-pretrained lightweight networks, **MobileNetV2** and **EfficientNet-B0**, fine-tuned on the same data. All models classify 64×64 traffic-sign images into 43 classes and are evaluated on accuracy, memory footprint and computational cost.

All models were implemented in Python with PyTorch, trained on the same data splits with the same augmentation, and timed on the same machine (NVIDIA GTX 1660 Ti GPU). The code, notebooks and every result file are in the GitHub repository: https://github.com/jaindusamaranayaka/EN3150-ConvNets-Image-Classifier.

2 Dataset and Data Preparation

2.1 Dataset

The **German Traffic Sign Recognition Benchmark (GTSRB)** [1] was used. It contains real-world photographs of 43 traffic-sign classes (speed limits, warnings, prohibitions and mandatory signs) under varying lighting, blur, partial occlusion and viewing angle. The original images range from about 15×15 to 250×250 pixels, so the dataset is naturally low resolution, which suits an edge-sensor scenario. The GTSRB training set (26,640 images, loaded through `torchvision`) was used and split into training, validation and test sets as required by the assignment.

2.2 Pre-processing

- **Resolution:** every image is resized to $64 \times 64 \times 3$, the maximum resolution allowed, to emulate a low-resource camera (Figure 2).
- **Normalisation:** pixel values are scaled to $[-1, 1]$ for the custom models. The pretrained models use the ImageNet mean and standard deviation, which their weights expect.
- **Augmentation (training set only):** random brightness and contrast ($\pm 20\%$), rotation ($\pm 8°$), translation ($\pm 5\%$) and scaling (0.95–1.05). Horizontal flips are deliberately *not* used, because flipping changes the meaning of some signs (e.g. "turn left" becomes "turn right").

2.3 Data Split

The images were split once, randomly with a fixed seed (42), and the split was saved to CSV files so that *every* model is trained and tested on exactly the same images (Table 1). The three sets are disjoint and all 43 classes appear in each. The classes are imbalanced, from 150 to 1,500 images per class (Figure 1); macro-averaged precision and recall are therefore reported alongside accuracy, so that rare classes count as much as common ones.

Table 1: Data split (seed 42).

Set	Images	Share
Training	18,648	70%
Validation	3,996	15%
Test	3,996	15%
Total	26,640	100%

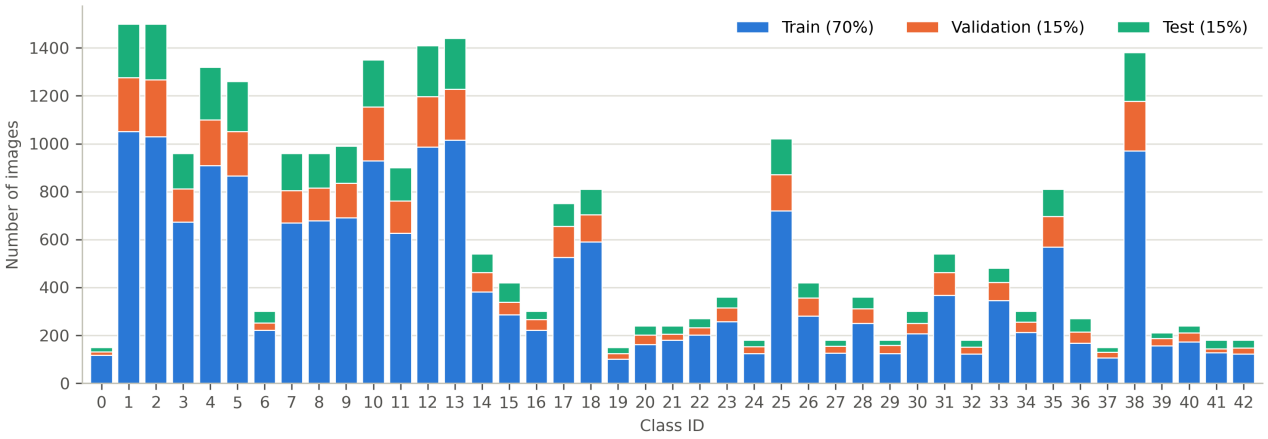


Figure 1: Number of images per class in each split. Every class keeps roughly the 70/15/15 proportion.



Figure 2: Training images after resizing to 64×64 and augmentation (black corners come from the random rotation).

3 Custom Architecture Design

Both custom models use the same four-stage layout so that they differ *only* in the type of convolution. Each stage halves the spatial resolution with 2×2 max-pooling while the channels grow $3 \to 16 \to 32 \to 32 \to 32$, giving a $32 \times 4 \times 4 = 512$-value feature vector that a single fully connected layer maps to the 43 class scores. The layer widths were kept small on purpose: with only four pooling stages and 32 final channels, the classifier stays at 22,059 parameters.

3.1 Model A: Standard CNN

Model A interleaves standard 3×3 convolutions (stride 1, padding 1) with ReLU and 2×2 max-pooling (stride 2). A standard convolution with kernel size k, C_{in} input and C_{out} output channels has

$$P_{\text{conv}} = k^2 \, C_{in} \, C_{out} + C_{out} \tag{1}$$

trainable parameters, and costs $H \cdot W \cdot k^2 \, C_{in} \, C_{out}$ multiply–accumulate operations (MACs) on an $H \times W$ output. Table 2 details every layer.

Table 2: Model A (standard CNN). Parameters and MACs per 64×64 image.

Layer	**Kernel**	**Filters / units**	**Output**	**Parameters**	**MACs**
Input	–	–	$3 \times 64 \times 64$	–	–
Conv2d + ReLU	3×3	16	$16 \times 64 \times 64$	$27 \cdot 16 + 16 = 448$	1,769,472
MaxPool	2×2	–	$16 \times 32 \times 32$	0	–
Conv2d + ReLU	3×3	32	$32 \times 32 \times 32$	$144 \cdot 32 + 32 = 4{,}640$	4,718,592
MaxPool	2×2	–	$32 \times 16 \times 16$	0	–
Conv2d + ReLU	3×3	32	$32 \times 16 \times 16$	$288 \cdot 32 + 32 = 9{,}248$	2,359,296
MaxPool	2×2	–	$32 \times 8 \times 8$	0	–
Conv2d + ReLU	3×3	32	$32 \times 8 \times 8$	9,248	589,824
MaxPool	2×2	–	$32 \times 4 \times 4$	0	–
Flatten	–	–	512	0	–
Fully connected	–	43	43	$512 \cdot 43 + 43 = 22{,}059$	22,016
Total				**45,643**	**9,459,200**

3.2 Model B: Lightweight CNN with Depthwise Separable Convolutions

Model B replaces each standard convolution with a **depthwise separable convolution** [2], which splits the operation into two cheaper steps:

1. a **depthwise** 3×3 convolution that filters each input channel separately (`groups =` C_{in}, no bias, since the next layer adds one), and
2. a **pointwise** 1×1 convolution that mixes the channels and produces C_{out} outputs,

followed by ReLU and the same max-pooling. Its parameter count and cost are

$$P_{\mathrm{DS}} = k^2\, C_{in} + C_{in}\, C_{out} + C_{out}, \qquad \mathrm{MACs}_{\mathrm{DS}} = H \cdot W \cdot (k^2\, C_{in} + C_{in}\, C_{out}), \tag{2}$$

so the cost relative to a standard convolution is $\frac{1}{C_{out}} + \frac{1}{k^2}$, about $\frac{1}{32} + \frac{1}{9} \approx 0.14$ for the $32 \to 32$ layers. Table 3 details every layer.

Table 3: Model B (depthwise separable CNN). Max-pooling, flatten and output shapes are identical to Model A.

Block	**Depthwise** 3×3 $k^2 C_{in}$	**Pointwise** 1×1 $C_{in}C_{out} + C_{out}$	**Parameters**	**MACs**	**Model A params**
$3 \to 16$	27	64	91	307,200	448
$16 \to 32$	144	544	688	671,744	4,640
$32 \to 32$	288	1,056	1,344	335,872	9,248
$32 \to 32$	288	1,056	1,344	83,968	9,248
FC $512 \to 43$	–	–	22,059	22,016	22,059
Total			**25,526**	**1,420,800**	**45,643**

Model B has **25,526** trainable parameters, well below the 100,000 limit, and needs **85% fewer MACs** than Model A (1.42 M vs 9.46 M). The convolutional layers shrink from 23,584 to 3,467 parameters, so the fully connected layer now holds 86% of Model B's parameters; any further reduction would have to target the classifier (e.g. global average pooling instead of flattening).

3.3 Hardware-Aware Choice of Activation Function

ReLU, $f(x) = \max(0, x)$, is used after every convolution in both models:

- **No transcendental functions.** ReLU is a single comparison per value. Sigmoid and tanh need an exponential for every activation, which is slow on microcontrollers without a floating-point unit and typically needs lookup tables or polynomial approximations.
- **Quantisation friendly.** ReLU is piecewise linear and works directly in 8-bit integer arithmetic, the usual format for deploying models on edge hardware.
- **Sparse activations.** Negative inputs become exactly zero, which reduces the work in later layers on hardware that skips zeros.
- **Max-pooling** likewise needs only comparisons, and **softmax is not needed at inference**: the predicted class is the arg-max of the logits, so the exponentials of softmax are only used inside the cross-entropy loss during training.

4 Optimizer Selection and Tuning

4.1 Experimental Set-up

The optimizer study was run as a controlled experiment on Model A: every run starts from the *same* saved random initialisation, sees mini-batches in the same order, and trains for 20 epochs with batch size 32 and cross-entropy loss. Only the optimizer changes. In addition to the three required optimizers, a momentum sweep ($\beta \in \{0, 0.5, 0.9, 0.99\}$) and a control run (plain SGD with $\eta = 0.1$) were added to explain the effect of momentum. Each run is tested with its final-epoch weights.

Table 4: Optimizer comparison on Model A (20 epochs).

Optimizer	Epochs to 95% val	Final train loss	Best val acc (%)	Test acc (%)	Test recall (%)	Batch-loss std
SGD ($\eta = 0.01$)	14	0.092	97.27	97.10	97.66	0.085
SGD + Momentum ($\eta = 0.01$, $\beta = 0.9$)	5	0.229	98.12	94.92	93.72	0.244
Adam ($\eta = 0.001$)	**4**	**0.031**	**98.92**	**98.15**	97.48	**0.056**
SGD + Momentum ($\beta = 0.5$)	8	0.040	98.25	95.62	96.48	0.063
SGD + Momentum ($\beta = 0.99$)	never	3.508	14.76	5.83	2.33	0.124
SGD ($\eta = 0.1$, control)	4	0.200	98.37	96.60	96.72	0.248



Figure 3: Training loss, validation loss (log scale) and validation accuracy for SGD, SGD + Momentum and Adam.

4.2 Selected Optimizer: Adam, $\eta = 0.001$

Adam [5] with the standard learning rate $\eta = 0.001$ ($\beta_1 = 0.9$, $\beta_2 = 0.999$) was selected for Models A and B (Figure 3):

- **Fastest convergence:** 95% validation accuracy after 4 epochs, compared with 5 for SGD + Momentum and 14 for plain SGD.
- **Best and most stable result:** the highest validation (98.92%) and test (98.15%) accuracy, the lowest final training loss (0.031) and the smoothest mini-batch loss in the last epoch (standard deviation 0.056).
- **No tuning required:** Adam adapts the step size of each parameter using running estimates of the mean and variance of its gradient, so the default $\eta = 0.001$ works without a learning-rate search. The SGD variants depend strongly on the hand-picked η and β, as Table 4 shows.

Plain SGD is stable but slow: during the first two epochs its loss barely moves from the value of random guessing ($\ln 43 \approx 3.76$), validation accuracy is only 71.6% after 5 epochs, and 95% is reached only at epoch 14. It finishes close to Adam (97.10% test) precisely because it never becomes unstable.

4.3 Impact of the Momentum Parameter

SGD with momentum keeps a decaying sum of past gradients, $v_t = \beta v_{t-1} + \nabla L$, and updates the weights with $w_{t+1} = w_t - \eta v_t$. Directions in which the gradient is consistent accumulate speed, while oscillating directions partly cancel. Figure 4 and Table 4 show the effect of β:

- **Faster convergence with larger β:** 14, 8 and 5 epochs to reach 95% validation accuracy for $\beta = 0$, 0.5 and 0.9.
- **Overshooting when β is too large:** with $\beta = 0.9$ the training loss is lowest at epoch 10 (0.089) and then rises to 0.229 by epoch 20, and the mini-batch loss is the noisiest of all runs (std 0.244). Its final weights are therefore worse than its best epoch (94.92% test vs 98.12% best validation). With $\beta = 0.99$ the velocity grows so large that training becomes unstable in the first epochs and never recovers: the loss stays near 3.5, close to random guessing.
- **Momentum mostly acts as a larger effective step.** With momentum the effective step size is about $\eta/(1-\beta)$, i.e. $0.01/0.1 = 0.1$ for $\beta = 0.9$. The control run, plain SGD with $\eta = 0.1$, behaves almost identically: 95% at epoch 4 (vs 5), similar late-training noise (std 0.248 vs 0.244) and the same late rise in training loss. Much of momentum's speed-up therefore comes from taking larger effective steps, not only from smoothing the gradient direction.

Getting momentum's early speed without the late instability would need a moderate β combined with a decaying learning rate. Adam provides fast and stable convergence without this tuning, which is why it was chosen. A preliminary three-optimizer run on Model B (batch size 128) also ranked Adam first.

5 Custom Model Training and Evaluation

5.1 Training Set-up

Both custom models were trained with an identical pipeline (Table 5), so the comparison isolates the effect of the convolution type.

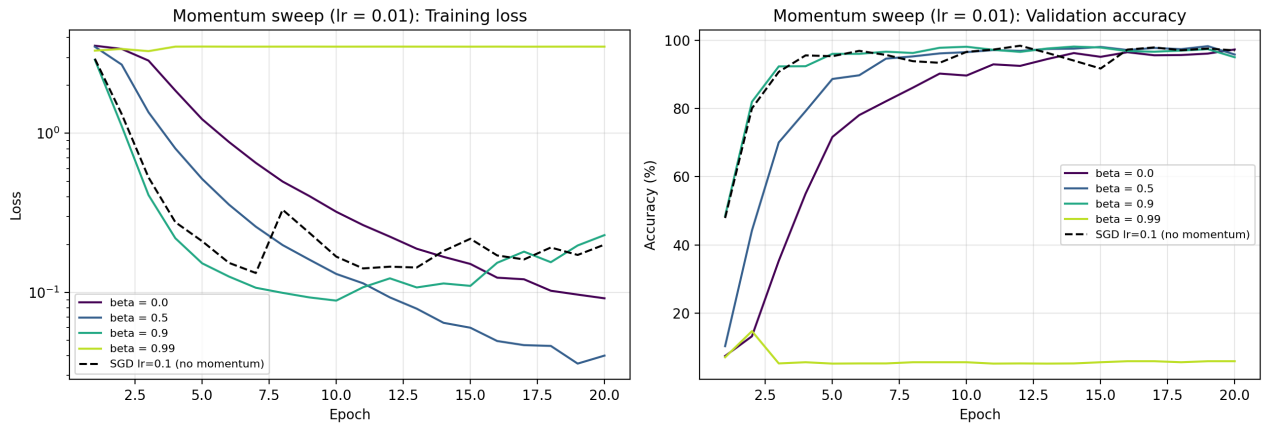


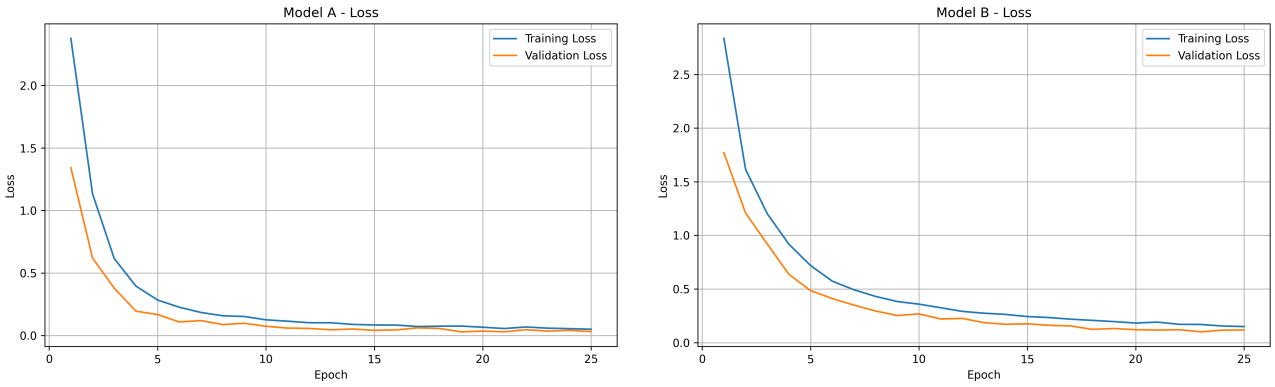
Figure 4: Momentum sweep at $\eta = 0.01$: training loss (log scale) and validation accuracy. The dashed line is the plain-SGD control run with $\eta = 0.1$, the same effective step size as $\beta = 0.9$.

Table 5: Training set-up for Models A and B.

Loss	Cross-entropy
Optimizer	Adam, $\eta = 0.001$
Epochs / batch	25 / 32
Weights tested	Epoch with the lowest validation loss
Reproducibility	Seed 42, deterministic cuDNN
Hardware	NVIDIA GTX 1660 Ti
Epoch timing	Median over all epochs, after an untimed pass that reads every image once

The median epoch time is reported because an earlier run showed that a single epoch can be slowed 2–3× by the first read of the dataset from disk or by other activity on the computer; the median is not affected by such outliers.

5.2 Training and Validation Loss



(a) Model A (b) Model B

Figure 5: Training and validation loss over 25 epochs.

Both models converge smoothly and show **no overfitting** (Figure 5): the validation loss keeps decreasing and stays below the training loss in every epoch. The training loss is higher because it is measured on augmented images, which are harder than the unaltered validation images. Model A

reaches 95% validation accuracy at epoch 6 and its best validation loss (0.029) at epoch 19. Model B learns more slowly (95% only at epoch 16), is still improving at epoch 25 (best validation loss 0.100 at epoch 23) and never reaches 99% validation accuracy, which indicates that it is limited by its capacity rather than by overfitting (Figure 6).

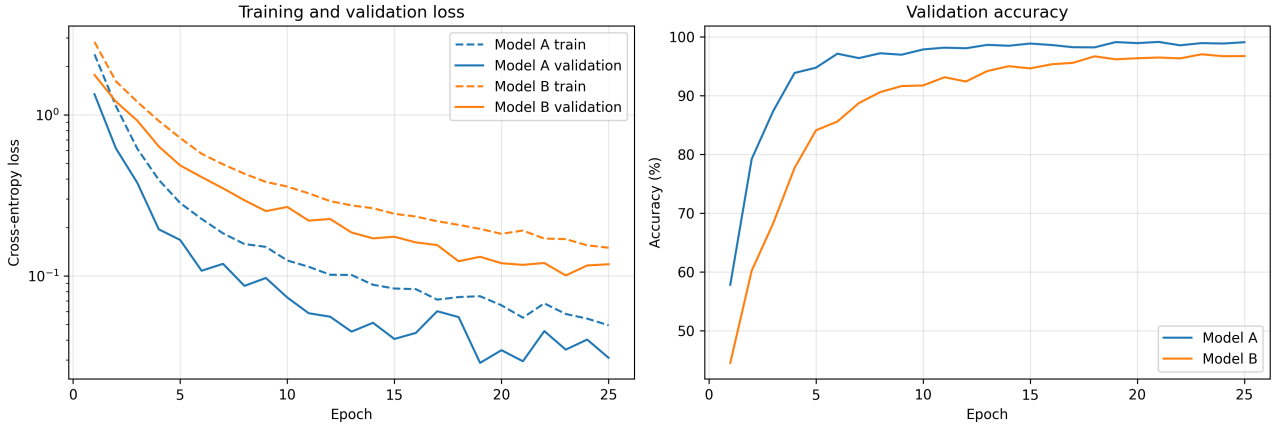
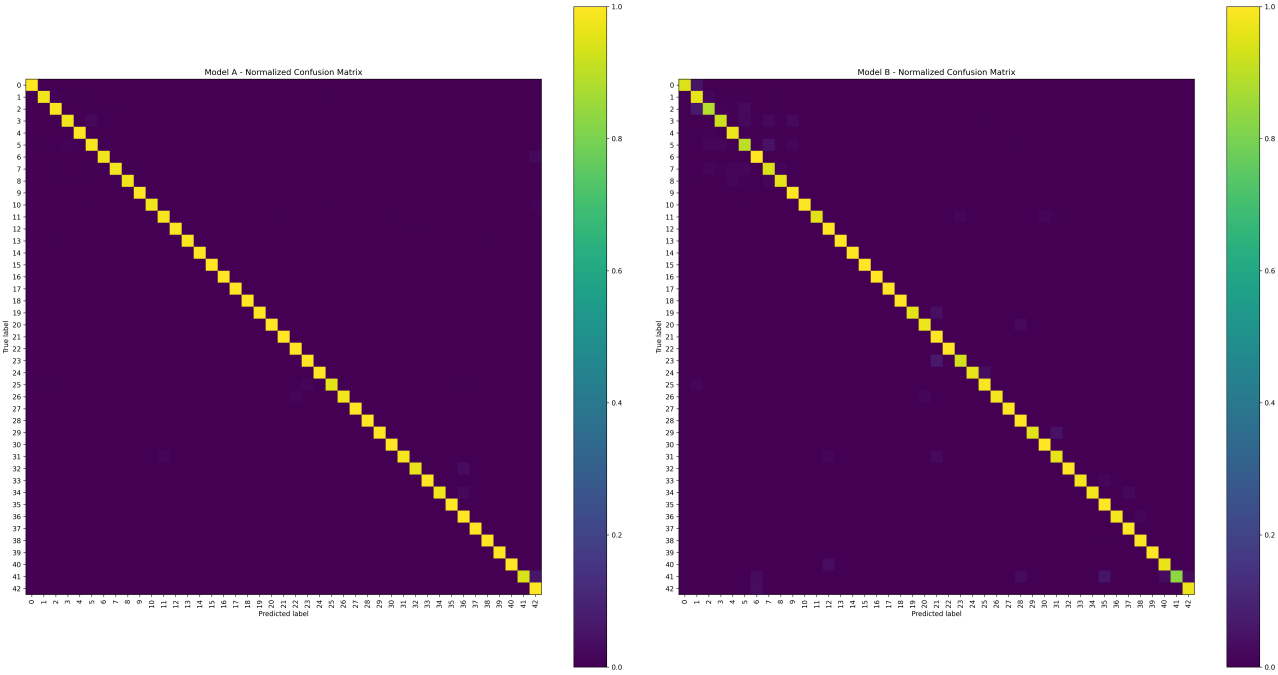


Figure 6: Model A vs Model B: training (dashed) and validation (solid) loss, and validation accuracy.

5.3 Test-Set Evaluation

Table 6: Test-set results (3,996 images). Precision and recall are macro-averaged over the 43 classes.

Model	Accuracy (%)	Precision (%)	Recall (%)	Misclassified
Model A	98.97	98.74	99.17	41
Model B	97.00	97.49	97.36	120



(a) Model A (b) Model B

Figure 7: Row-normalised confusion matrices on the test set (true class vs predicted class).

Model A misclassifies 41 of the 3,996 test images and Model B 120 (Table 6). Both confusion matrices (Figure 7) are strongly diagonal. The remaining errors concentrate in the top-left block of **speed-limit signs** (classes 0–8), which share the same red circle and differ only in their digits. Model B's most frequent error is predicting *30 km/h* for a *50 km/h* sign (16 times), and its lowest recalls are for 50 km/h (88.8%), 80 km/h (90.0%) and 60 km/h (92.6%), together with *end of no passing* (class 41, 82.9%, a rare class with 35 test images). Signs with distinctive shapes or colours, such as stop, yield or no entry, are classified almost perfectly by both models.

5.4 Model A vs Model B

Table 7: Comparison of the two custom models.

Metric	Model A	Model B	Change
Trainable parameters	45,643	25,526	−44.1%
Model size on disk (KB)	182.8	105.7	−42.2%
MACs per image	9.46 M	1.42 M	−85.0%
Training time per epoch (s)	41.0	44.2	+7.8%
GPU inference (ms/image)	0.36	0.34	−4.9%
Test accuracy (%)	98.97	97.00	−1.98 pts

Trade-offs when moving to depthwise separable convolutions (Table 7):

- **Memory and computation drop sharply.** Model B is 42% smaller on disk and needs 85% fewer MACs. In 8-bit form it would need only about 25 KB, small enough for the flash memory of a microcontroller.
- **Accuracy drops slightly.** The test accuracy falls by 2 percentage points (3× more errors). Separating spatial filtering from channel mixing reduces the model's capacity to learn fine, multi-channel patterns such as the digits on speed-limit signs.
- **Fewer MACs did not mean faster training on the GPU.** Model B is 7.8% *slower* per epoch. It has twice as many layers (eight convolutions instead of four), and each layer has a fixed launch and memory-transfer overhead. Depthwise convolutions perform very little arithmetic per value loaded, so a GPU cannot use its parallelism efficiently, and most of each epoch is spent loading images, which is identical for both models. Model B's single-thread CPU latency was likewise no lower than Model A's (1.61 vs 1.52 ms, Section 7). The MAC savings only translate into real speed on hardware where arithmetic is the bottleneck and depthwise convolutions are optimised, for example microcontroller libraries such as CMSIS-NN or TensorFlow Lite Micro.
- **Slower convergence.** Model B needs about three times as many epochs to reach 95% validation accuracy.

6 Fine-Tuning Lightweight State-of-the-Art Networks

6.1 Selected Models

- **MobileNetV2** [3] is built from inverted residual blocks: a 1×1 expansion, a depthwise 3×3 convolution and a linear 1×1 projection, with ReLU6 activations ($\min(\max(0, x), 6)$), which are cheap and bounded, and therefore quantisation friendly.
- **EfficientNet-B0** [4] uses MBConv blocks (the same inverted-residual idea) with squeeze-and-excitation attention, and its depth, width and resolution were found by neural architecture

search. It uses SiLU (Swish) activations, $x \cdot \sigma(x)$, and sigmoid gates, which need an exponential for every value.

6.2 Fine-Tuning Procedure

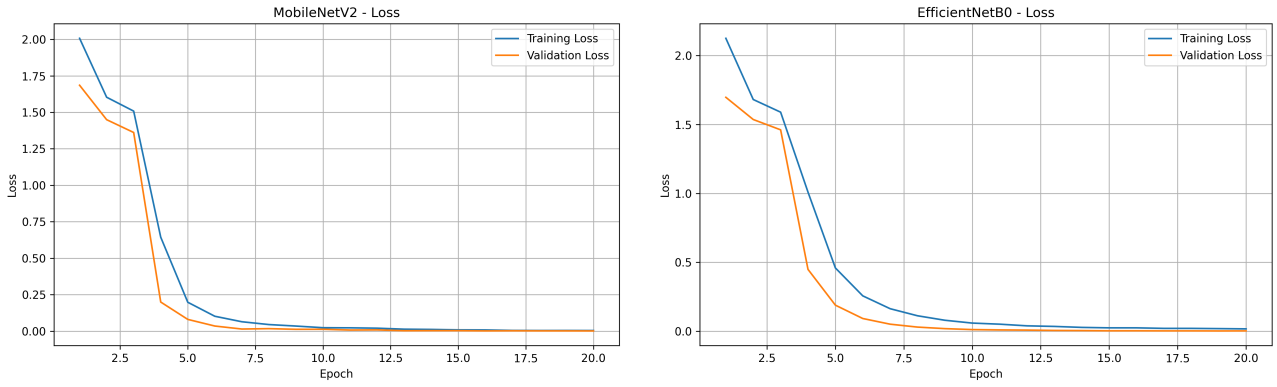
Both networks were loaded with ImageNet weights, their 1000-class output layer was replaced by a new $1280 \to 43$ linear layer, and they were trained with an identical recipe on the same splits and augmentation as the custom models:

1. **Head warm-up (3 epochs):** the pretrained backbone is frozen and only the new head is trained (Adam, $\eta = 10^{-3}$), so its random initial gradients cannot damage the pretrained features.
2. **Full fine-tuning (17 epochs):** all layers are unfrozen and trained with Adam at a $10\times$ smaller learning rate ($\eta = 10^{-4}$) with cosine decay.

The input was kept at 64×64 rather than upsampled to the networks' native 224×224: upsampling adds no information but would multiply the computation by about $(224/64)^2 \approx 12$, which defeats the purpose of an edge model. The weights with the lowest validation loss were used for testing.

Table 8: Fine-tuned SOTA models (test set: 3,996 images).

Metric	**MobileNetV2**	**EfficientNet-B0**
Total parameters (all trainable)	2,278,955	4,062,631
of which new 43-class head	55,083	55,083
Model size on disk (MB)	8.93	15.79
MACs per 64×64 image	24.50 M	32.02 M
Test accuracy (%)	100.00	99.82
Macro precision / recall (%)	100.00 / 100.00	99.87 / 99.91
Misclassified test images	0	7
First epoch with $\geq 99\%$ val. accuracy	7	8
Training time per epoch, full fine-tuning (s)	55.8	70.1



(a) MobileNetV2 (b) EfficientNet-B0

Figure 8: Training and validation loss during fine-tuning (backbone unfrozen after epoch 3).

Table 8 summarises both models and Figure 8 shows their training. With only the head trained, validation accuracy stalls at 58% (MobileNetV2) and 56% (EfficientNet-B0): ImageNet features alone do not separate 64×64 traffic signs well, because these images look very different from ImageNet photographs and the backbone's final feature map is only 2×2. As soon as the whole network is unfrozen, accuracy jumps to 93% and 86% after a single epoch and passes 99% by epoch 7–8. Both models reach near-perfect test accuracy and show no overfitting.

7 Final Comparison and Trade-off Discussion

7.1 Results

Table 9 compares the custom resource-constrained model (Model B) with the fine-tuned SOTA models; Model A is included as a reference. To reflect an edge device more closely than a GPU, each architecture was also timed on the CPU with **one thread and one image at a time** (median of 200 runs). The estimated 8-bit size assumes one byte per parameter.

Table 9: Accuracy, memory footprint and computational cost of all models.

Metric	Model A	Model B	MobileNetV2	EfficientNet-B0
Accuracy				
Test accuracy (%)	98.97	97.00	100.00	99.82
Macro precision (%)	98.74	97.49	100.00	99.87
Macro recall (%)	99.17	97.36	100.00	99.91
Memory footprint				
Parameters	45,643	25,526	2,278,955	4,062,631
Model size on disk (MB)	0.179	0.103	8.93	15.79
Estimated 8-bit size (MB)	0.044	0.024	2.17	3.87
Computational cost				
MACs per image (M)	9.46	1.42	24.50	32.02
CPU latency, 1 thread (ms)	1.52	1.61	6.94	10.35
GPU inference (ms/image)	0.36	0.34	0.60	0.67
Training time per epoch (s)	41.0	44.2	55.8	70.1

Table 10: Cost of each SOTA model relative to Model B, and the accuracy it gains.

Model	Parameters	Size	MACs	CPU latency	Accuracy
MobileNetV2	89×	87×	17×	4.3×	+3.00 pts
EfficientNet-B0	159×	153×	23×	6.4×	+2.83 pts

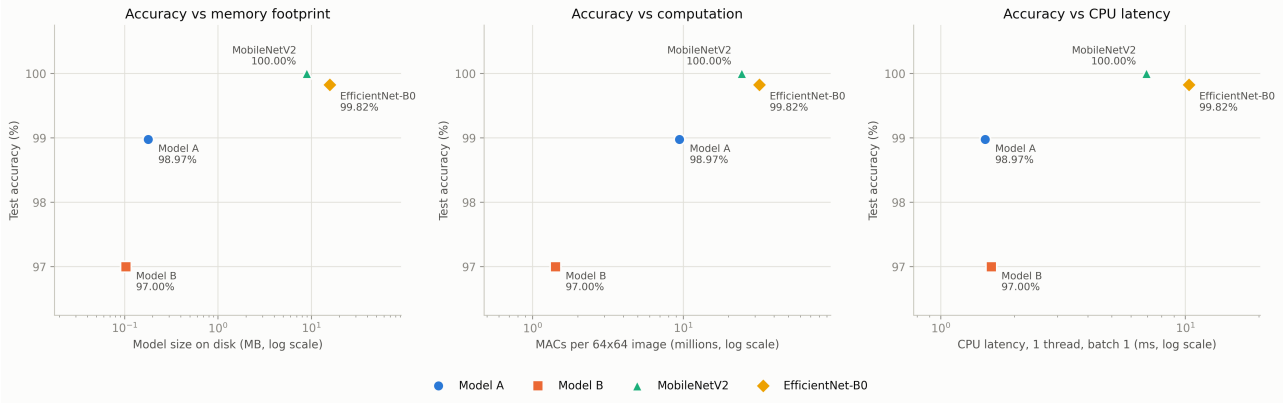


Figure 9: Test accuracy against model size, MACs and single-thread CPU latency (logarithmic x-axes). Up and to the left is better.

Table 11: Recall (%) on the eight classes where Model B is weakest.

Class	Sign	Test images	Model A	Model B	MobileNetV2	EfficientNet-B0
41	End of no passing	35	94.29	82.86	100.00	100.00
2	Speed limit 50	233	99.14	88.84	100.00	98.71
5	Speed limit 80	209	98.56	89.95	100.00	99.52
3	Speed limit 60	148	97.97	92.57	100.00	100.00
23	Slippery road	44	100.00	93.18	100.00	100.00
7	Speed limit 100	155	98.06	94.19	100.00	100.00
0	Speed limit 20	19	100.00	94.74	100.00	100.00
29	Bicycles crossing	21	100.00	95.24	100.00	100.00

7.2 Discussion

Table 10 expresses each SOTA model's cost as a multiple of Model B's, and Figure 9 places all four models on the accuracy–memory–computation trade-off.

Accuracy. The pretrained models are about 3 percentage points more accurate than Model B (100.00% and 99.82% vs 97.00%), and the gain is concentrated on the fine-grained classes where Model B struggles (Table 11): MobileNetV2 recognises every speed-limit sign correctly, while Model B confuses signs that differ only in their digits. ImageNet pretraining gives the large models rich features for edges, strokes and shapes, which a 25,526-parameter network trained from scratch on 18,648 images cannot fully learn. Pretraining also speeds up learning: the SOTA models pass 99% validation accuracy by epoch 7–8, a level Model B never reaches (Figure 10).

Memory footprint. This is where Model B wins decisively. At 0.10 MB in 32-bit floating point, or about 25 KB in 8-bit form, it fits comfortably in the flash and RAM of typical microcontrollers, which have a few hundred kilobytes to a few megabytes. MobileNetV2 and EfficientNet-B0 are 87× and 153× larger and still need 2.2–3.9 MB after 8-bit quantisation, which rules them out for most microcontrollers but is acceptable on a Raspberry Pi-class device.

Computational cost. Model B needs 17–23× fewer MACs, and on a single CPU thread it is 4.3–6.4× faster than the SOTA models; this matters directly for battery life and frame rate on an edge device. The latency ratio is smaller than the MAC ratio because these small models are partly limited by per-layer overhead rather than arithmetic. The same effect explains why Model B is not faster than Model A on this desktop CPU and GPU despite 85% fewer MACs. EfficientNet-B0 is the least efficient model here: it is larger, slower and slightly less accurate than MobileNetV2, because its design was tuned for 224×224 inputs and its SiLU activations and squeeze-and-excitation gates require exponentials.

Custom sub-100k model: advantages and limitations.

+ Tiny memory footprint (25 KB in 8-bit form) and very low compute; deployable on microcontrollers.
+ Uses only operations that are cheap and widely supported on edge hardware (convolution, ReLU, max-pooling).
+ No dependence on large pretrained weights or a 224-pixel input; the architecture is fully under control and can be shaped for a specific device.
– Lower accuracy on fine-grained classes, slower convergence, and a design that needs manual exploration.
– Its theoretical savings only become real speed with optimised depthwise kernels on the target hardware.

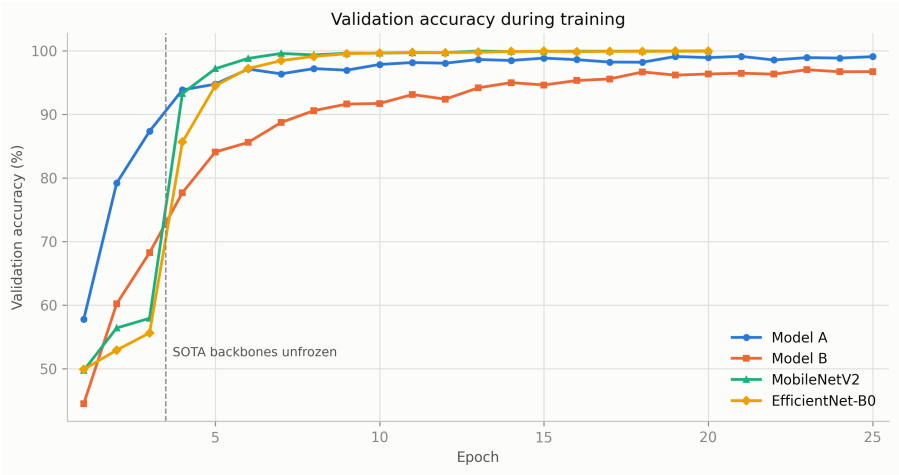


Figure 10: Validation accuracy per epoch for all four models. The pretrained models are unfrozen after epoch 3.

Pretrained lightweight model: advantages and limitations.

+ Highest accuracy and fastest convergence thanks to transfer learning; little architecture design needed.

– 2–4 MB even when quantised, 17–23× the MACs and 4–6× the latency of Model B; too large for most microcontrollers.

– Designed for 224 × 224 inputs; at 64 × 64 much of their capacity is unused.

Recommendation. For a microcontroller-class device, Model B offers the best balance: 97% accuracy within about 25 KB and 1.4 M MACs per image. If the device has megabytes of memory (e.g. a Raspberry Pi) and the highest accuracy is required, MobileNetV2 is the better choice: it is more accurate, smaller and faster than EfficientNet-B0.

7.3 Limitations

- **Optimistic test accuracy.** GTSRB's training images come in *tracks* of about 30 consecutive frames of the same physical sign. Because the split was random by image, every one of the 883 sign tracks in the test set also has frames in the training set. Test images are therefore very similar to training images, which inflates all accuracies; the 100% of MobileNetV2 should be read in this light. A track-wise split, or the official GTSRB test set, would give a more realistic estimate of accuracy on unseen signs. The comparison between models remains fair, because all of them use the same split.

- **Timing on desktop hardware.** Latency was measured on a desktop CPU and GPU with 32-bit floating point. Real edge latency depends on the device, the inference library and 8-bit quantisation, which were not evaluated.

- **Single run.** Each model was trained once with a fixed seed; small accuracy differences (e.g. between the two SOTA models) are within run-to-run variation.

8 Conclusion

Two custom CNNs and two pretrained lightweight networks were trained and compared for 64 × 64 traffic-sign classification. Replacing standard convolutions with depthwise separable convolutions cut

parameters by 44% and MACs by 85% (Model B: 25,526 parameters) at a cost of 2 percentage points of test accuracy (97.00% vs 98.97%). Adam with $\eta = 0.001$ trained fastest and most stably; momentum accelerates SGD but overshoots when β is too large. Fine-tuned MobileNetV2 and EfficientNet-B0 reached 100.00% and 99.82% test accuracy, but are 87–153× larger and need 17–23× more computation than Model B. For memory-constrained edge devices, a carefully designed sub-100k-parameter model offers a far better balance of accuracy, memory and computation, while pretrained models are preferable when memory is not the limiting factor. Fewer MACs, however, only become faster inference with hardware and libraries optimised for depthwise convolutions.

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